

ported Siri to the iPhone 4, but the experience is sluggish.

8. Bells and whistles

The difference between a few closely performing models (GPUs or CPUs) is a multiplier lock. Companies produce a few chips (2-3) which are then binned (tested and categorised) according to performance. The good ones are stable at higher clock speeds and accordingly are labelled as High-end SKUs while the



Now with a brand new name!

not-so-good ones end up with a multiplier lock and are labelled as mid-range. Thus one or two chips make for the entire Mid-High range of SKUs. The same goes for Low-Mid range of SKUs. Sometimes there are absolutely no hardware differences, and purely software limitations. Lower-end GPU SKUs are mostly rebranded models of the previous architecture. The 6650M was a rebranded 5650 desktop chip, which was *again* recently rebranded as the 7650M. Same goes for NVIDIA's 675M which is a rebranded 580M. So the shiny "new" GPU that your new laptop came with isn't new at all. Intel had similarly come with its "Processor Power Upgrade" for \$50 in the US to remove a software limitation put on their mobile processors. The idea didn't catch on (fortunately) and Intel canned the plan.

<http://dgit.in/OkDPzQ>

9. Marketing mumbo-jumbo

For years, people looking to buy audio systems were being suckered by an insane amount of wattage – PMPO (peak music power output). Eventually everyone and his uncle learnt to disregard that. Then it was monitors and TVs, with dynamic contrast ratios (DCR) that skyrocketed into the realm of sci-fi! You cannot compare two products by their rated PMPO or DCR. The DCR is dynamically adjusted backlight depending on what picture is

displayed. So if the display has a dark image then the backlight is turned down a lot to get better black levels. The reverse is applied for bright images, and then the difference calculated. Obviously idiotic, because at any given time, your screen at any one setting would never be able to replicate those levels of black or white.

<http://dgit.in/PRRONx>

10. Wacky warranty

Not all products have their warranty period starting from the date of purchase, rather it starts from its date of import/production. Sometimes there is an offset period of 2-3 months post manufacturing. So if you end up purchasing something 1-2 years after it has been made, it's quite possible that it's not covered by warranty already! Another anomaly is the existence of dealer warranty and manufacturer warranty, the former being less reliable. If you get manufacturer warranty, it's because the product is imported legally by a distributor. If you're getting dealer warranty, it could be anything from smuggled goods not meant for India, or refurbished products.

11. Spare parts

When your product needs to be repaired, you'll rarely be told that it's a faulty component that needs to be replaced. Rather an entire module will be replaced and you'll be charged a bomb for that. LCD monitor's power boards and AC control boards are a common example. Even if all that has failed is a little capacitor, the technician will only offer to have a new PCB put in place, rather than replace the faulty component. The difference? A capacitor costs between ₹4 and ₹300. PCBs can cost a few thousand rupees. This is also why when your laptop gives way, and you ask the manufacturer to repair it, you always seem to get an estimate of ₹10,000 and above. Big brands are usually closer to ₹20,000. However, a reputed repairing firm in your city could do a pretty decent repair job for as little as ₹2,000. Sometimes with and without warranty, depending on the part that failed. Microcontrollers are a different story, and are often SMT (Surface Mount Technology). They need to be programmed before being placed on a board, and it's probably best to get PCB replacement in this case.

12. Planned obsolescence

Companies realised that better build quality would lead to consumers purchasing less in the long run. Thus came planned obsolescence wherein products were designed to fail deliberately after a certain amount of time.

Printers have kill switches which stops the printer from being able to utilise a cartridge after a certain period of time or makes the printer stop completely after a certain page count, even if it is still perfectly capable of working.

Read more about this on page 56.

<http://dgit.in/QGN0qC>

13. Metered unlimited?

Commonly done under the guise of a Fair Usage Policy which usually dictates that each customer is allowed to transfer a certain amount of data at the maximum bandwidth of the plan and once that limit is achieved, the speed is drastically brought down to roughly 1/8th of the actual bandwidth. This is done because



you might "impair the experience of other users".

Technically this means that the plan is not unlimited, however, companies will rarely mention this

before you opt-in. That agreement will clearly state that the plan is Unlimited and define its fair use policy too, but that isn't the definition of unlimited. Almost all major ISPs namely, Airtel, Idea, Tata, etc., in the country have implemented this system so far. If you are paying for an unlimited plan, then you have the right to download however much you want at the maximum speed stated in the agreement. Make sure you read your agreement, and avoid ISPs that have this policy.

<http://dgit.in/OigwDx>

Follow the provided dgit.in links for further reading. Also the following link bundle has all of the above links and more.

<http://dgit.in/ROpt9B>

Watch out for our next month's cover story, which will give you all the buying tips you need, across categories, to ensure you don't fall prey to these and more tricks that are being used to get you to part with your money. 